Cold Chain Temperature Excursion Response

Document	Revision	Effective	Owner
SOP-OPS-002	3	2025-01-10	Northgate Distribution, Quality Assurance

1. Purpose

This procedure defines what to do when a cooler or freezer goes outside its safe temperature range, so that product safety decisions are consistent and documented.

2. Temperature Limits

Storage type	Target	Investigate when	Product hold when
Cooler (CU-400 units)	34F to 38F	Above 41F for 30 min	Above 41F for more than 2 hours
Freezer (EV-220 units)	-15F to -5F	Above 0F for 30 min	Above 10F for more than 60 minutes

3. Response Steps

1. **Within 15 minutes:** the shift lead confirms the alarm by checking the unit display and a calibrated hand thermometer.
2. **Within 15 minutes:** open a P1 work order under SOP-OPS-003 and call the on-call refrigeration technician.
3. **Within 30 minutes:** if the unit cannot be restored, move product to a backup unit. Load the most temperature-sensitive product first (dairy, fresh meat, then produce; for freezers, ice cream first).
4. Record start time, peak temperature, end time and product moved on form QA-17 Temperature Excursion Log.
5. If a product hold limit in Section 2 was exceeded, tag affected pallets HOLD and notify Quality Assurance.
6. **Within 24 hours:** QA decides product disposition: release, discount, or destroy.

4. Root Cause

The technician records the fault code and root cause in the work order. Common causes are door left open, high head pressure (E-21), defrost termination failure (DF-4) and power loss. Any unit with two excursions in 30 days gets a full inspection.

5. Records

Keep QA-17 forms and temperature charts for 2 years.